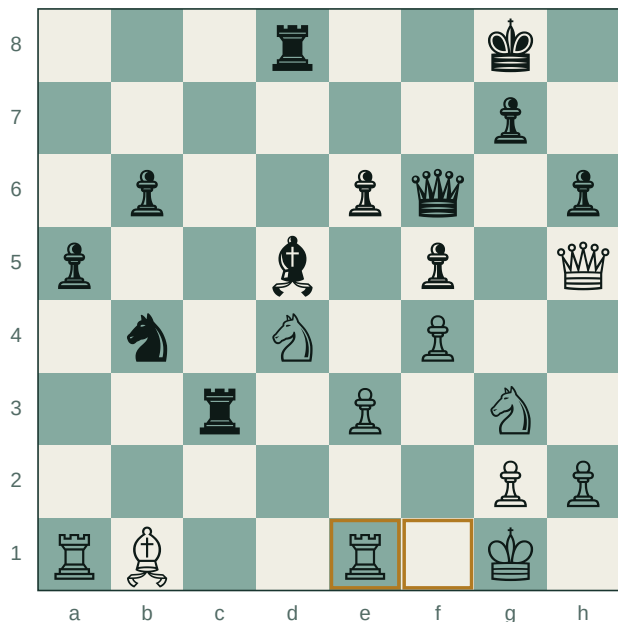


Capture the defender: Black, move 26

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Re1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Rxe3 27. Rxe3 Qxd4 28. Nxf5 exf5

26...Rxe3 The rook captures the pawn on e3. From e3 it attacks rook on e1 and knight on g3. Recorded reply: **27.Rxe3**.

27...Qxd4 The queen captures the knight on d4. From d4 it attacks rook on e3 and rook on a1. Recorded reply: **28.Nxf5**.

28...exf5 The pawn captures the knight on f5.

At the end, nominal material is White 25 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1**: the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on e1 and rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.